



Amir Anderson Animator Toolkit

Animate faster and learn as you go — a toolkit panel for After Effects.

User Guide

by Amir Anderson · Version 1.0

1 · Start Guide

What's in This Download

- **Amir_Anderson_Animator_Toolkit.zxp** — the plugin. This is the only file you need to install.
- **Animator_Toolkit_Quick_Start_Guide.pdf** — this document.
- **Amir_Anderson_Animator_Toolkit.zip** — optional: the same plugin with install scripts, for installing without a ZXP installer.
- **INSTALL.md** — install steps, tips and troubleshooting (inside the zip).
- **LICENSE.txt** — the license: a plain-language summary and the full terms.

What It Does

Animator Toolkit puts everyday animation jobs one click away: setting anchor points, adding keyframes, easing, ready-made entrances and exits, text animation, masks, 3D, cameras, fast previews, audio fades and still grabs. Every button tells you what it did, and short lessons explain the “why” as you go.

Everything it changes is a normal After Effects edit: one click is one undo, and your layers stay fully editable in the timeline.

Requirements

- Adobe After Effects 2021 (18.0) or later
- macOS or Windows

Install (about two minutes)

1. Install a ZXP installer app once — **ZXP Installer** (aescripts.com/learn/zxp-installer, recommended) or **Anastasiy's Extension Manager** (install.anastasiy.com). A .zxp is Adobe's package format for extensions; this small free app opens it.
2. Open the installer, drag **Amir_Anderson_Animator_Toolkit.zxp** into it, and click **Install**.
3. If a one-time “unverified developer” notice appears, click through it — the plugin is signed, just not through Adobe's paid developer program. On macOS: **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Open Anyway**. On Windows: **More info** → **Run anyway**.
4. **Fully quit** After Effects (Cmd+Q on a Mac, File → Exit on Windows) and reopen it.

5. Open **Window** → **Extensions** → **Amir Anderson Animator Toolkit**. The panel docks like any other AE panel.

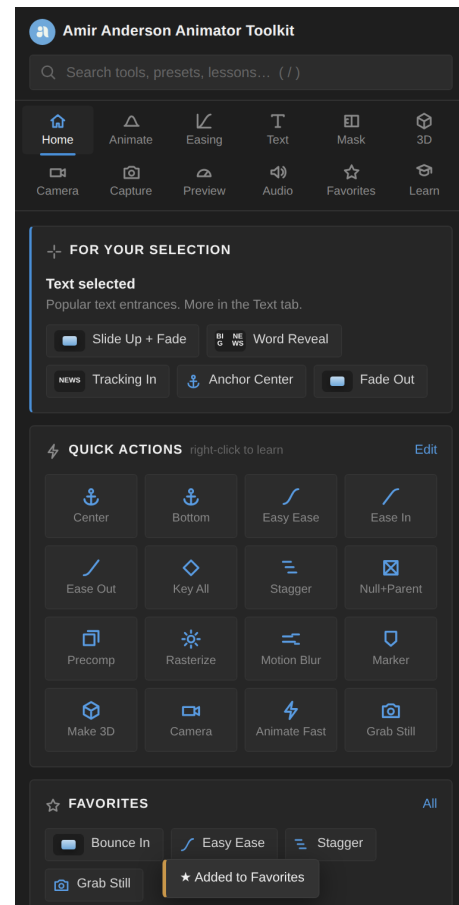
Your First Animation (60 seconds)

1. Select a layer in your comp's timeline.
2. Open the **Animate** tab and make sure **Entrance** is chosen.
3. Click **Slide Up + Fade**. The layer now slides up and fades in, with real keyframes you can edit.
4. Press **Spacebar** in After Effects to play it.

Changed your mind? **Cmd+Z** (Mac) / **Ctrl+Z** (Windows) undoes it in one step — or click **Undo** on the message the panel shows.

2 · The Interface

The panel has a title bar with your **Search** box, a row of **tabs** (one per kind of job), and the tools for the tab you're on. Click the logo or name at the top to visit Amir Anderson on LinkedIn.



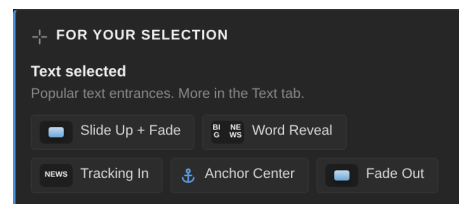
The panel, open on the Home tab.

The Tabs

Tab	What it's for
Home	Suggestions for your selection, your Quick actions, and the 5 essential skills.
Animate	Anchor points, align, keyframes, Stagger, and the entrance and exit library.
Easing	Easy Ease, ease in and out, curve presets, bounce, elastic and overshoot.
Text	New text, plus animations by letter, word or line.
Mask	Animated wipes and reveals, and mask tools.
3D	Make layers 3D, spread them in depth, and extrude 3D text.
Camera	Create a camera, then push, pull, orbit, shake and focus.
Capture	Grab Still: save the current frame as a PNG.
Preview	Animate Fast and Final Check setups, and faster previews.
Audio	Levels and fades for audio layers.
Favorites	Your own kit of the tools you use most.
Learn	Short lessons, quick fixes and explained shortcuts.

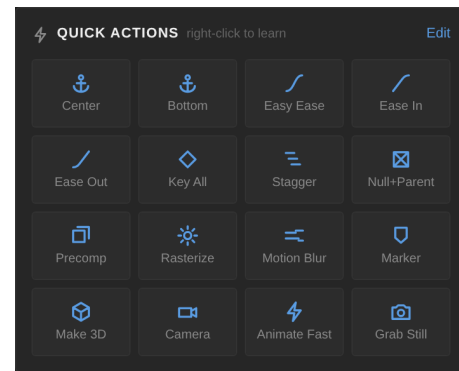
Home

For your selection changes with what you select in After Effects. Select a text layer and it offers text entrances; select keyframes and it offers easing.



Suggestions for a selected text layer.

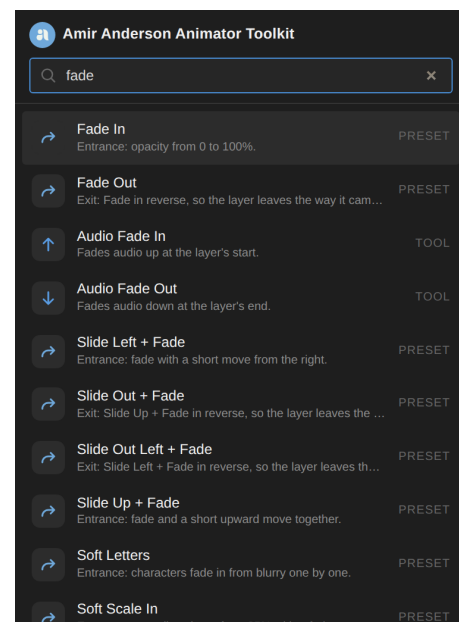
Quick actions are one-click buttons for everyday jobs. Click **Edit** to add or remove buttons; anything you remove can be added back later.



Quick actions. Right-click any button to learn what it does.

Search

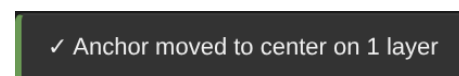
Press **/** or click the search box, then type what you want to do, such as *fade*, *bounce* or *camera*. Results include tools, presets, lessons and shortcuts. Click a result to use it, or press **Enter** for the top one.



Searching for “fade.”

Messages and Undo

After every click, a short message at the bottom of the panel says what changed. In After Effects, the message also has an **Undo** button. Every change is a single step in **Edit** → **Undo**, so **Cmd/Ctrl+Z** works too.



The message after moving an anchor point.

Getting Help Inside the Panel

- **Hover** over any button to see what it does.
- **Right-click** a tool to see what it does, why it's useful and what it needs.
- If a button needs something (for example, a selected layer), the message tells you exactly what to select.

Stagger

Offsets selected layers one after another by a number of frames, in the order you selected them.

Why: Staggering (cascading) lets several elements share one animation but arrive one after another — the eye reads them in order.

Needs: one or more layers selected.

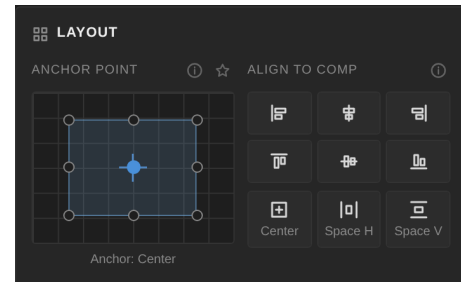
Right-click a tool for a short explanation.

3 · Tab by Tab

You don't need to learn every tab at once. Start with Animate, Easing and Preview, and come back to the others when you need them.

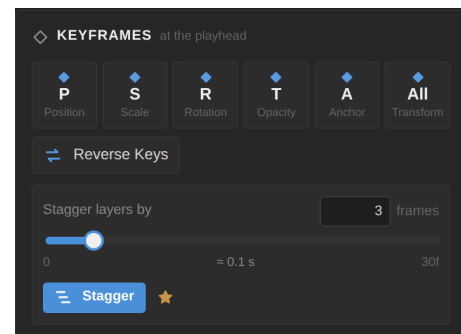
Animate

Anchor Point: click a dot on the grid to move a layer's anchor point without the layer jumping. **Align:** line layers up with the comp, or space three or more layers evenly.



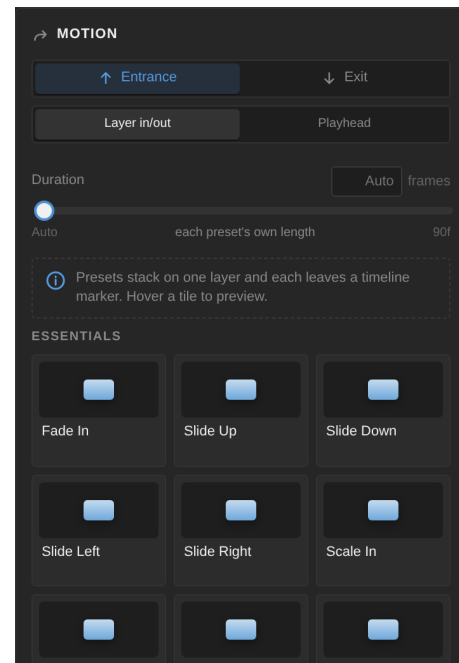
The anchor grid and Align buttons.

Keyframes: add a keyframe for Position, Scale, Rotation, Opacity, Anchor Point or all of them at the playhead. **Reverse Keys** plays the selected keyframes backward. **Stagger** offsets the selected layers by a number of frames so they animate one after another.



Keyframe buttons and Stagger, set in frames.

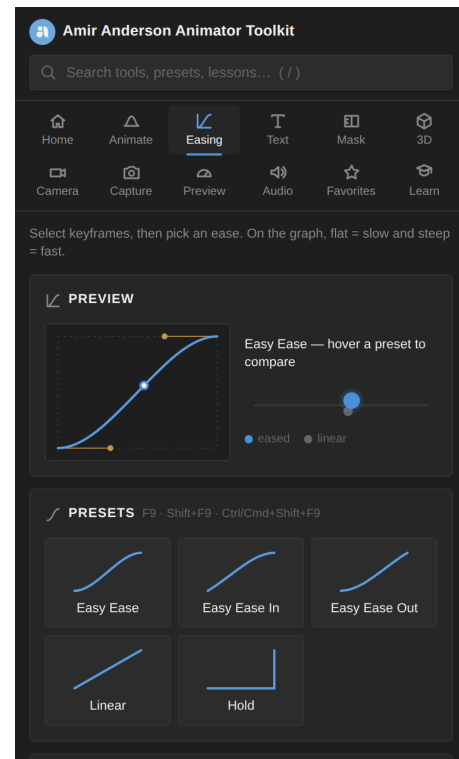
The **Motion** library holds ready-made animations. Choose **Entrance** or **Exit**, choose whether it starts at the layer's In/Out point or at the playhead, and set a duration in frames (or leave it on Auto). Hover a tile to preview it, then click to apply. Presets can be stacked on one layer.



The Motion library: pick Entrance or Exit, then a tile.

Easing

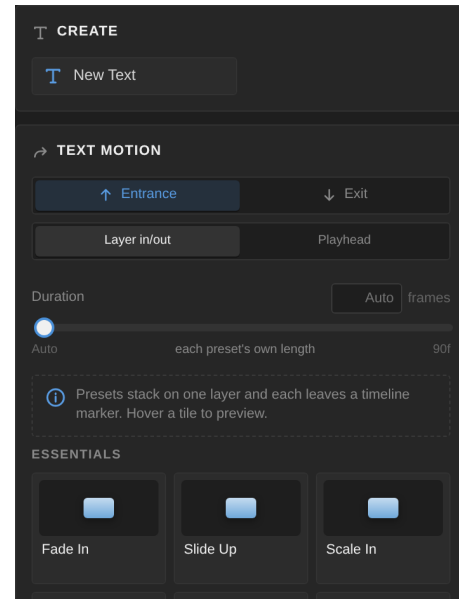
Select two or more keyframes, then click **Easy Ease**, **Ease In** or **Ease Out**. The live curve shows the shape of the motion. Curve presets go from subtle to dramatic, the physics buttons add real **Overshoot**, **Bounce** or **Elastic** keyframes, and the influence sliders set exactly how soft each side is.



The live curve: blue is eased, gray is linear.

Text

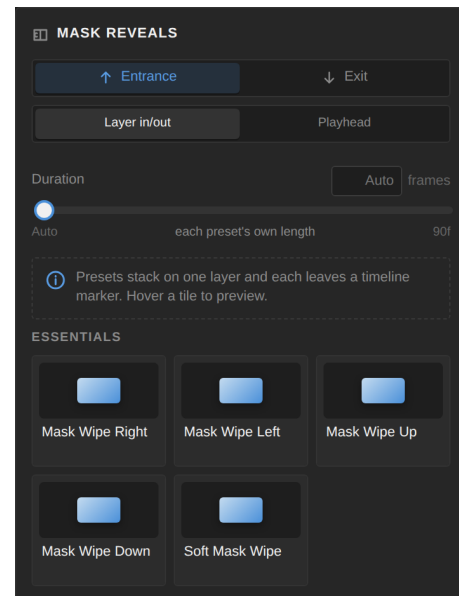
Click **New Text** for a centered text layer, or select a text layer and pick a preset. Letter, word and line tiles build a real Text Animator you can open in the timeline and adjust. Layer presets such as Fade and Slide work on any layer.



Text presets by letter, word or line.

Mask

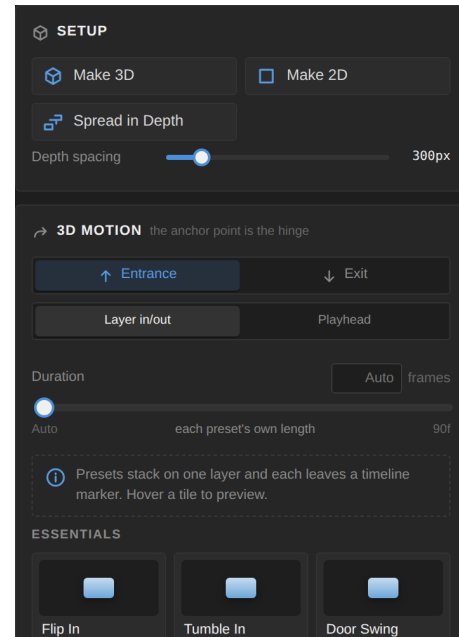
Select a layer, then pick a reveal: wipes, iris or split. Each one builds a real, animated mask (press **M** in the timeline to see it). The mask tools add a rectangle or ellipse mask, invert masks, or feather their edges.



Animated mask reveals.

3D

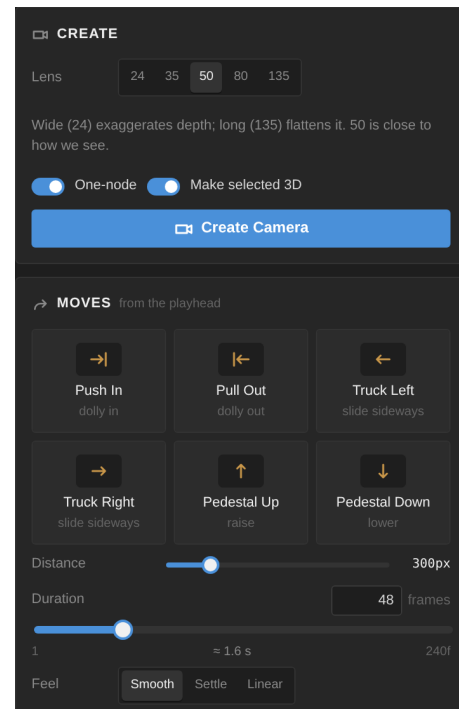
Make 3D turns on a layer's 3D switch. **Spread in Depth** places the selected layers one behind another, which creates parallax when a camera moves. For extruded 3D text, click **Advanced 3D** first, then select text or shape layers and click **Extrude**.



3D tools and the renderer switch.

Camera

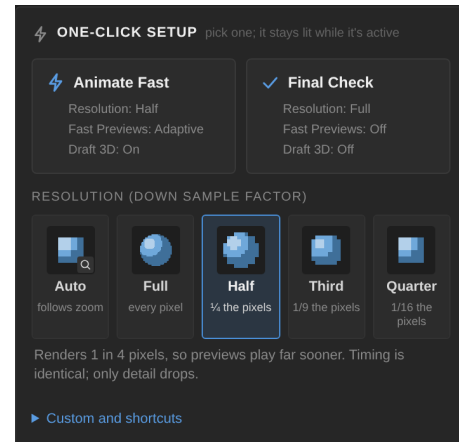
Pick a lens and click **Create Camera**. Then use the **Moves** (Push In, Pull Out, Truck, Pedestal) from the playhead, with a distance, a duration in frames and a feel. Further down are lens zoom, depth of field, orbit and shake tools, and saved camera positions.



Create a camera, then add moves.

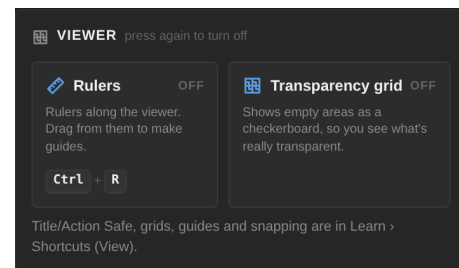
Preview

Click **Animate Fast** while you work for smooth, real-time playback (Half resolution, Adaptive Fast Previews and Draft 3D; the timing never changes). Click **Final Check** before you render to see every pixel at full quality. The resolution cards switch between Auto, Full, Half, Third and Quarter.



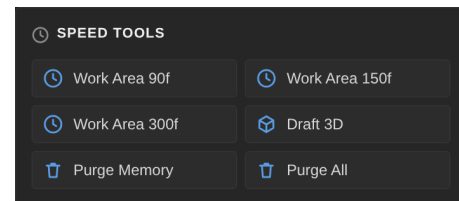
One-click setup and the resolution cards.

The **Viewer** cards turn the rulers and the transparency grid on and off. Press a card again to turn it off.



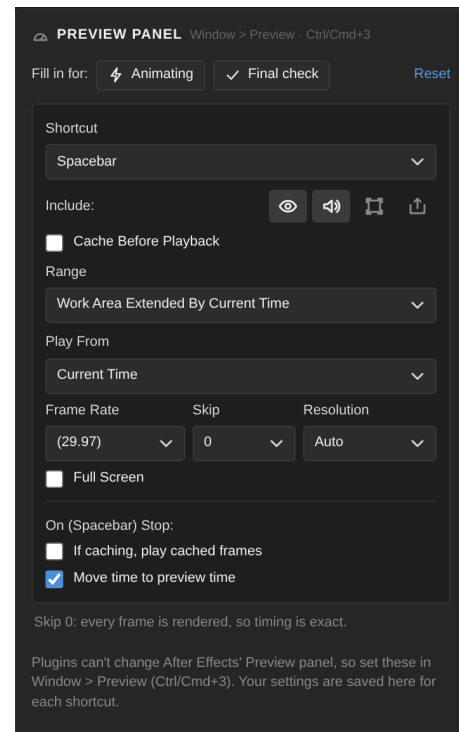
Rulers and Transparency grid.

Speed tools: the **Work Area** buttons set a 3-, 5- or 10-second work area starting at the playhead, so previews only play what you're working on. **Draft 3D** speeds up 3D scenes. **Purge Memory** clears cached frames; **Purge All** also clears the disk cache (After Effects asks you to confirm).



Speed tools.

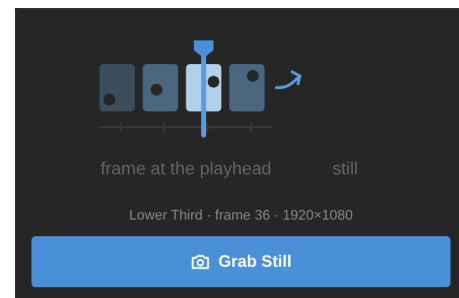
After Effects doesn't let plugins change its Preview panel, so the **Preview panel** card shows the right settings for each preview shortcut. Click **Animating** or **Final check** to fill them in, then copy them into **Window** → **Preview** (Cmd/Ctrl+3).



The Preview panel planner mirrors After Effects' Preview panel.

Capture

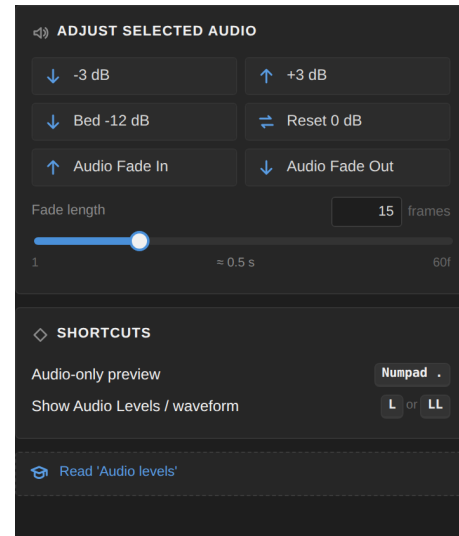
Click **Grab Still** to save the frame at the playhead as a PNG. A pop-up shows the image and where it was saved. Click **Change** to pick a different folder, and turn on **Import into project** to add the still to your Project panel too.



Grab Still saves the frame under the playhead.

Audio

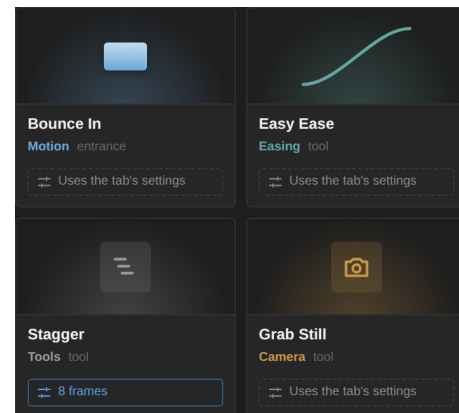
Select an audio layer. Lower or raise it by 3 dB, set it to -12 dB for music under a voice-over, reset it to 0 dB, or fade it in or out at the layer's start or end.



Audio levels and fades.

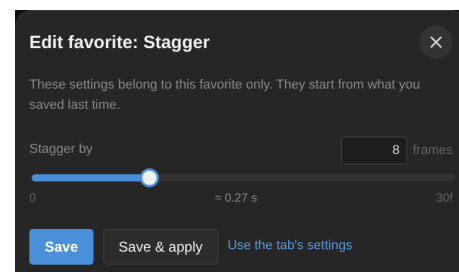
Favorites

Click the **star** icon on any tool, preset or lesson to add it here. Click a card to use it, double-click its name to rename it, and use the arrows to reorder your kit.



Favorites, with Stagger saved at 8 frames.

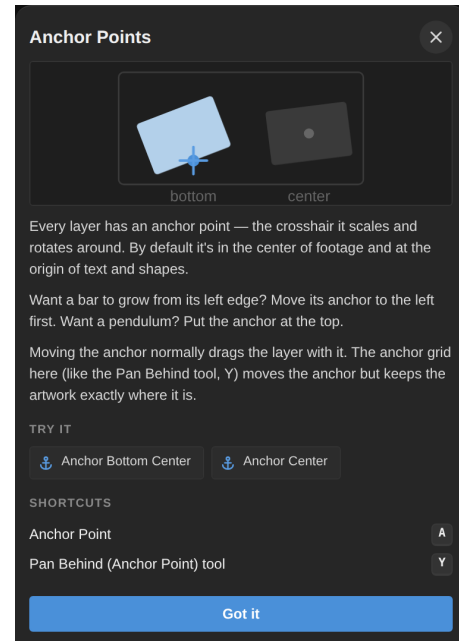
Click the **sliders** button on a card to give that favorite **its own settings**, for example Stagger by 8 frames, without changing the tab it came from. **Save** keeps the settings, **Save & apply** also runs it, and **Use the tab's settings** switches it back.



Editing a favorite's settings.

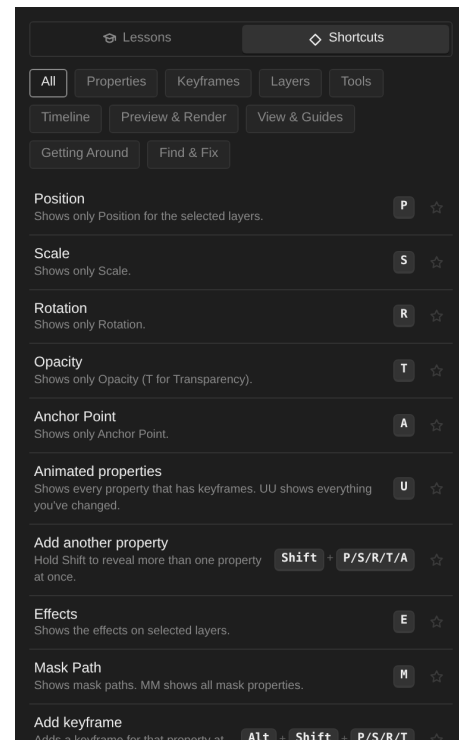
Learn

Short lessons (two minutes or less) cover the essentials, animation principles and production tips, plus **quick fixes** for common problems. Many lessons have a **Try it** button that runs the tool for you.



A lesson, with Try it buttons and the related shortcuts.

The **Shortcuts** list explains After Effects' keyboard shortcuts in plain words, including Title/Action Safe, grids, guides and snapping.



Shortcuts, explained.

4 · A Fast Animation Workflow

Here's a simple way to go from still layers to smooth, finished motion using the panel.

1. **Set up for speed.** In **Preview**, click **Animate Fast** so playback stays real-time while you work.
2. **Fix the anchor point.** Select your layers and, in **Animate**, click a dot on the anchor grid.
3. **Add motion.** Click an **Entrance** tile such as Slide Up + Fade, or add your own keyframes with the **Keyframes** buttons.
4. **Shape the timing.** Select the keyframes and click **Easy Ease** in **Easing**. Want more life? Try **Overshoot** or **Bounce**.
5. **Stagger it.** Select several layers and click **Stagger** so they come in one after another.
6. **Check it.** Before rendering, click **Final Check** in **Preview** to see full quality.
7. **Share a frame.** Click **Grab Still** in **Capture** to send a quick approval image.

Tips for a Clean Workflow

- Star the tools you use every day so they're waiting in **Favorites** and on **Home**.
- Timing is in **frames**, with the seconds shown underneath, so it matches your timeline.
- Every change is one undo, so experiment freely.

Keyboard Shortcuts

- **/** — jump to Search: find any tool, preset, lesson or shortcut by name.
- **Esc** — close Search or any pop-up.
- **Cmd/Ctrl+Z** — native After Effects undo.

5 · Words to Know & Troubleshooting

Word	What it means
Keyframe	A saved value at a moment in time. Two keyframes with different values make an animation.
Easing	How motion speeds up and slows down between keyframes.
Anchor point	The point a layer scales and rotates around.
Playhead	The blue marker that shows the current frame in the timeline.
Frames	The unit of timing. At 30 fps, 30 frames is one second.
Work area	The part of the timeline that previews play.
Null	An invisible layer used as a handle to move other layers.
Parenting	Linking layers so a child layer follows its parent.
Pre-comp	A group of layers packed into its own composition.
Resolution	How many pixels the viewer draws. Lower is faster; the timing stays the same.

Troubleshooting

- **Plugin doesn't appear under Window → Extensions** — fully quit and reopen After Effects.
- **Nothing happens when you double-click the .zxp** — install ZXP Installer or Anastasiy's Extension Manager first, then open the .zxp through that app.
- **macOS says it can't verify the developer** — System Settings → Privacy & Security → Open Anyway.
- **A red banner says the panel can't reach After Effects** — click **Retry**. If it stays, restart After Effects.
- **Previews stutter or show old frames** — click **Purge Memory** or **Purge All in Preview**.

Questions or feedback — Amir Anderson · [linkedin.com/in/amiranderson](https://www.linkedin.com/in/amiranderson)

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